

LESSON 0 · INTRODUCTORY/OPTIONAL
THE SYRIAC ALPHABET

Note: *This lesson is supplementary to the 12-lesson course plan. It is recommended for students with no prior exposure to Syriac script. Students who already read Estrangela may proceed directly to Lesson 1.*

The Alphabet and the Light: The Estrangela Script

SECTION 1: INTRODUCTION TO THE SCRIPT

Syriac is written from **right to left**. The script used in this course is **Estrangela** (ܐܪܬܪܢܓܠܐ), meaning “rounded.” It is the oldest and most formal of the three Syriac scripts, and it is the primary script used in the earliest manuscripts of the Peshitta and the Acts of the Martyrs.

Core Principles:

1. **22 Consonants:** All letters are consonants. Vowels are indicated by separate small marks or dots (to be covered in Lesson 1).
2. **Connecting Letters:** Most letters connect to the preceding and following letters (like cursive or Arabic). However, 8 letters are “non-joiners” — they only connect to the letter before them.
3. **No Case:** There are no capital letters.
4. **Alaph as Carrier:** The first letter, Alaph (ܐ), is often a silent carrier for a vowel or a glottal stop.

SECTION 2: THE 22 LETTERS (THE ABGAD SYSTEM)

Syriac letters follow the same order as Hebrew and the ancient “Abgad” order of Arabic.

Letters 1–11

ESTRANGELA	NAME	TRANSLIT	PHONETIC	HEBREW	ARABIC
א	Alaph	ʾ	Glottal stop/silent	א	أ
ב	Beth	b / v	b as in ‘boy’	ב	ب
ג	Gamal	g / gh	g as in ‘go’	ג	ج
ד	Dalath	d / dh	d as in ‘dog’	ד	د
ה	He	h	h as in ‘house’	ה	ه
ו	Waw	w	w as in ‘water’	ו	و
ז	Zain	z	z as in ‘zebra’	ז	ز
ח	Heth	ḥ	Pharyngeal ‘h’	ח	ح
ט	Teth	ṭ	Emphatic ‘t’	ט	ط
י	Yodh	y	y as in ‘yes’	י	ي
כ	Kaph	k / kh	k as in ‘king’	כ	ك

Letters 12–22

ESTRANGELA	NAME	TRANSLIT	PHONETIC	HEBREW	ARABIC
𐤌	Lamad	l	l as in 'light'	ל	ل
𐤍	Mim	m	m as in 'man'	מ	م
𐤎	Nun	n	n as in 'noon'	נ	ن
𐤏	Semkath	s	s as in 'sun'	ס	س
𐤐	'e	'	Pharyngeal stop	ע	ع
𐤑	Pe	p / f	p as in 'paper'	פ	ف
𐤒	Sade	ṣ	Emphatic 's'/'ts'	צ	ص
𐤓	Qoph	q	Uvular 'k'	ק	ق
𐤔	Rish	r	Rolled 'r'	ר	ر
𐤕	Shin	š	sh as in 'she'	ש	ش
𐤖	Taw	t / th	t as in 'tall'	ת	ث

SECTION 3: JOINERS VS. NON-JOINERS

In your reading, you will notice that certain letters never connect to the letter following them. This creates a small visual gap within a word.

The Non-Joiners (Letters that only connect to the RIGHT):

𐤀 (Alaph), 𐤇 (Dalath), 𐤅 (He), 𐤍 (Waw), 𐤏 (Zain), 𐤑 (Sade), 𐤔 (Rish), 𐤖 (Taw).

Note: Taw (𐤖) often appears to connect, but technically follows the non-joiner rule in many formal manuscripts.

Dalath (𐤇) and Rish (𐤔) look identical except for a single dot: Dalath has a dot BELOW, Rish has a dot ABOVE.

SECTION 4: PRACTICE TABLE — VISUAL RECOGNITION

WORD	TRANSLIT	MEANING	ANALYSIS
ܐܠܗܐ	Alāhā	God	Alaph (NJ) + Lamad + He (NJ) + Alaph
ܡܠܟܐ	malkā	King	Mim + Lamad + Kaph + Alaph (NJ)
ܐܪܥܐ	’ar ‘ā	Earth	Alaph (NJ) + Rish (NJ) + ‘ e + Alaph
ܢܘܪܐ	nūhrā	Light	Nun + Waw (NJ) + He (NJ) + Rish (NJ) + Alaph
ܝܘܚܢܢ	Yūḥannan	John	Yodh + Waw (NJ) + Heth + Nun + Nun

SECTION 5: THE STORY — PART 0

The Scribe’s Beginning

Note: The story in this introductory lesson (*‘The Scribe’s Beginning’*) is a standalone narrative used to practice the alphabet. The main course narrative (*The Acts of Mar Yukhannan*) begins in Lesson 1.

Narrative note: Before the Acts of Mar Yukhannan begin, we see the scribe, Addai, preparing the parchment. This part introduces the visual rhythm of the script.

ܐܢܐ ܐܕܕܝܐܝܐ ܣܥܦܪܐ

’enā ‘Adday sāp̄rā.

’ENĀ (I) ‘ADDAY (ADDAI) SĀPRĀ (THE-SCRIBE)

I am Addai the scribe.

ܡܠܟܐ ܕܐܠܗܐ ܡܠܬܐ

kāteb ’enā meltā d-Alāhā.

KĀTEB (WRITING) ’ENĀ (I) MELTĀ (THE-WORD) D- (OF) ALĀHĀ (GOD)

I am writing the word of God.

ܡܠܟܐ ܕܝܘܗܢܢ

hannū ktābā d-Yūhannan.

HANNŪ (THIS-IS) KTĀBĀ (THE-WRITING/BOOK) D- (OF) YŪḤANNAN (JOHN)

This is the book of Yukhannan.

SECTION 6: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Alphabet Order

Write the following three letters in their Abgad sequence (the order used in the table in Section 2).

1. ܘ, ܟ, ܐ

2. ܕ, ܡ, ܝ

3. ܝ, ܕ, ܐ

Exercise 2: Identify the Non-Joiners

In the word ܢܗܪܐ (nūhrā, Light), which letters are non-joiners (do not connect to the letter on their left)?

Exercise 3: Transcription Practice

Write out the Syriac letters for the following names based on Section 2:

1. M-L-K-A (King)

2. A-L-H-A (God)

3. Y-W-H-N-N (Yukhannan / John)

Exercise 4: Directional Awareness

If you are reading the word ܡܠܟܐ, which letter do you read first (the one on the far right or the far left)?

SECTION 7: ANSWER KEY

Exercise 1

1. א, ב, ג (A-B-G)
2. ד, ה, ו (H-T-Y)
3. ז, ח, ט (Q-R-S)

Exercise 2

ו (Waw), ה (He), ר (Rish), א (Alaph). All of these stop the cursive connection.

Exercise 3

1. ספר
2. מגלת
3. עפר

Exercise 4

The letter on the far RIGHT (א - Alaph).

SECTION 8: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The 22 letter names learned in Section 2 (Alaph, Beth, Gamal ... Taw) count as the first 22 vocabulary items of this lesson. The 8 words below complete the set of 30, all drawn from the world of scribal culture that frames this course.

ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	GENDER/TYPE	MEANING
סגול	Estrangelā	f	“Rounded” script
ספרא	sāprā	m	Scribe, writer
סבא	ktābā	m	Book, scripture
סגולת	megalltā	f	Scroll
סרש	qarṣā	m	Parchment
סלמ	qalmā	m	Pen, reed
סלמ	dīyūtā	f	Ink
סלמ	nāmūsā	m	Law (from Gk Nomos)